# Where You Are: The Planning Step, What Came Before It and Who Is Involved After It

The nine steps of the Medicaid Planning Roadmap, with yours marked.

When Mom needs long-term care now, you hear about applications, attorneys and paperwork all at once, and it can sound as if every part of it belongs to this week. There is a general order to it, and it helps to see it laid out as steps, with the one you're on marked.

This page shows the whole road, where the planning step sits on it, what it produces, and who is involved next.

## Phase 1 · Assess

Understand where you are today.

1 **Understand** Care Needs → Levels of Care & Costs → Care Plan
You finish with: Immediate Care Needs Assessment

2 **Organize** Income & Assets → Ownership & Expenses → Financial File
You finish with: Financial Snapshot & Care Cost Analysis

3 **Assess** Care & Nonfinancial Eligibility → Income & Assets → Barriers & Readiness
You finish with: Medicaid Readiness Assessment

## Phase 2 · Plan

Develop and implement your strategy.

4 **Plan** Barriers & Issues → Priorities & Professional Team → Written Plan
You finish with: Medicaid Action Plan

**You are here.** This step turns what you know about Mom's care, her finances and where things stand with Medicaid into a written plan. It moves from barriers and open issues, to priorities and the professional team, to the plan on paper. It is finished when everyone can answer what happens next, who is responsible, and in what order things need to happen.

5 **Legal** Authority & Documents → Property, Trusts & Transfers → Attorney Review
You finish with: Legal Issues & Attorney Review Brief

6 **Financial** Costs & Runway → Asset Treatment & Tools → Strategy & Documentation
You finish with: Financial Strategy & Implementation Plan

## Phase 3 · Secure

Secure benefits, protect assets, and maintain eligibility.

7 **Apply** Prepare → Submit → Manage
You finish with: Medicaid Application File

8 **Protect** What May Be Protected → What May Remain Exposed → What Needs Ongoing Attention
You finish with: Asset Protection Report

9 **Maintain** Ongoing Requirements → Changes & Renewals → Maintenance System
You finish with: Medicaid Maintenance Plan

## What came before it

Three steps come before this one: understanding Mom's care needs, organizing her finances, and assessing where things stand with Medicaid. Each leaves something on paper, and the plan is built from all three.

If your family arrived at this step first because Mom needs care now, the planning conversation can start from a short summary of each, with the gaps marked as questions.

## What this step produces

The Medicaid Action Plan: a written, prioritized plan of what needs to happen, in what order, and who is responsible for each part. It is worked out with your Medicaid planner from Mom's facts.

It is a plan, not a decision about eligibility. The federal Administration for Community Living explains that each state takes the applications and makes the eligibility determinations, and that eligibility rules vary from state to state. [1] [2]

## What happens next

Two steps carry the plan out: the legal step and the financial step. After them come Apply, Protect and Maintain. The roadmap shows them in a general order. Which of them your family needs, and in what order for Mom, is what the plan itself says.

An elder law attorney reviews parts of the plan in this step and does the work of the legal step. The Administration for Community Living lists preparing power of attorney documents and exploring a person's qualifications for Medicaid among the things elder law attorneys do. [3]

## Who is involved, by role

- You and your family: gathering, writing down, asking, and making the decisions that are yours to make.
- Mom: her own wishes, as far as she can share them.
- Your Medicaid planner: brings the care, financial and Medicaid findings together, names the known barriers and open issues, and works with the family to separate what must happen now from what can wait and to put the actions in order, with a name beside each one.
- An elder law attorney: reviews the decisions that belong to an attorney before the written plan is settled. Legal advice and legal documents are the attorney's, in the step that follows.
- A licensed financial or insurance professional: reviews the financial and insurance decisions that belong to them before the plan is settled.
- An applications specialist and the state Medicaid agency: the application is prepared with a specialist, and the state makes the decision. That is step seven.

**What this page doesn't promise**

How long any step takes, who will be available, or how things turn out. It doesn't put your family's own actions in order, and nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice. Families move through the steps at different speeds.

## Ready for the next step?

You know where the planning step sits, what it produces and who is involved next. The planning interview is a way to walk into it prepared: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to the planning conversation, or to any other conversation about paying for care.

**Get Your Free Planning Report ›**

### WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The nine steps are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own. The statements about who takes applications, who decides eligibility and what elder law attorneys do come from the Administration for Community Living.


1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Applying for Medicaid
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Will I Need a Lawyer?


---